"To find yourself, think for yourself."
-Socrates

ACADEMIC WRITING:

Essay Structure

Developed and compiled by
Michael Warrick

THE INTRODUCTION

1. Which of the following items of information are *necessary* (N), *optional* (O) or *unnecessary* (U) for the introduction of a short essay (about 400-500 words)? **Discuss with your ideas with a partner:**

a) Definitions of terms in the title that are unclear or have a specialized meaning _____

b) A thesis statement _____

c) Your final opinion on a discussion generated in the main body of the essay _____

d) General background information on the topic _____

e) A question to interest the reader _____

f) More specific information that shows the importance of the topic _____

g) A geographical and/or chronological limitation that you have set yourself _____

2. Complete this order for the information outlined above. **You should include only the *necessary* and *optional* types of information:**

1. …... **2.** (a) **3.** …... **4.** (g) **5.** …….

3. What is a thesis statement? **Decide if the following statements are true or false:**

The thesis statement:

a) gives the topic of the essay but does not offer any indication of the contents of main body paragraphs

b) is usually found at the end of the introductory paragraph

c) may be in the form of a question

d) often begins with a phrase such as: "The purpose of this essay is to…" or "This essay will…"

e) should refer to the title of the essay and copy words from it where possible

f) often contains a key question verb, such as: *discuss/examine/analyse/investigate*, *describe,* etc.

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SAMPLE INTRODUCTION I

1. Reorder the following sentences to create a coherent introduction:

ESSAY TITLE: *Describe the advantages and disadvantages of city life.*

a) On the other hand, metropolitan areas that are often densely populated may present an array of challenges to the quality of life. _____

b) In recent years, a growing number of country dwellers have migrated to the city in search of a better life. _____

c) The purpose of this essay is to characterize the benefits and drawbacks of urban living with regard to sense of community, pollution, entertainment, medical care and educational facilities. _____

d) The reasons why such large numbers are moving to urban settings undoubtedly relate to the considerable range of amenities and opportunities on offer. _____

e) This trend seems set to continue, as the ratio of the global urban population is projected to rise from 55% in 2018 (4.2 billion citizens) to 68% by 2050 (European Commission, 2018). _____

2. Analyze the thesis statement

a) Note the key question verb that introduces the writer's thesis statement. ……..

b) Underline the main points to be covered in the main body. …….

c) Which main point will be mentioned last in the main body? ……..……..

d) Which words in the thesis statement have paraphrased *advantages*, *disadvantages*, *city* and *life* from the essay title?

……..……..……..…….

e) Give two synonymous words/expressions for *with regard to* ……..…….

……

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SAMPLE INTRODUCTION 2

ESSAY TITLE: ……

……

; ……

……

1. Reorder the following sentences to create a coherent introduction:

a) Culture shock is perhaps the most serious problem they encounter, especially in countries whose cultures differ markedly from their own. _____

b) China is the largest source of international students, with around 703,500 Chinese students pursuing overseas studies in 2019 (Ministry of Education of the People's Republic of China, 2020). _____

c) This essay will examine the issues Chinese students encounter while at university in the UK in respect of homesickness and the language barrier, and solutions will be evaluated. _____

d) At the same time, at least in the short term, they can face particular hardships far away from their own culture and family. _____

e) Chinese students who go abroad may benefit academically, economically, and psychologically from the experience. _____

2. Analyze the thesis statement:

a) Note down the key question verb that introduces the writer's thesis statement: ……..……

b) What will be the second problem mentioned in the main body? ……..……...

……

c) Which word (a hypernym) does homesickness refer back to in the same sentence? ……...

Hypernym: *a word whose meaning includes a group of other words: 'The first hypernyms for dog that come to mind would be animal or pet.'*

3. Write what you consider is a suitable title for the above essay introduction.

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THE OPENING SENTENCE OF AN INTRODUCTION

It can be difficult to start writing an essay, and hesitation, especially in exams, can waste valuable time. An opening sentence often (but not always!) has the following pattern:

Time phrase	Topic	Development
Currently,	many multinational corporations	are focusing on enhancing their reputation in order to gain a competitive advantage.

The opening sentence often contains a time-phrase, followed by a verb in the appropriate tense.

1. Give the tense and correct form for each verb in parentheses:

a) *In the late 20th century* Finland (experience) ……..…….. record-breaking warm winters, but also some rather cold and snowy winters.

b) *At present* greenhouse gas emissions from the household sector (account) …….. for almost one-fifth of Australia's total emissions (The Climate Institute, 2015).

c) *The last decade* (see) …… a rapid expansion in the number of hotels and other tourism facilities in Qatar.

d) *Traditionally*, businesses (rely) …… on multiple vendors and service providers for their technology and networking needs.

e) *The 1990s* (characterize) ……. by the massive growth of prison populations throughout Western societies (Garland, 2001).

f) The Western Black Rhino and Northern White Rhinos *recently* (go) ……..…….……. extinct in the wild.

g) *Currently*, Italy (be) ……. the 8th largest export economy in the world, and its main export markets are Germany, France and the US (Workman, 2018).

h) *In the past*, surgeons (have) ……. to make large incisions in order to reach the organs during a surgical procedure.

i) *In recent years*, the streaming of classes by ability (become) ……..…… a highly controversial issue.

2. Which time phrases have a similar meaning? ……

……..

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ESSAY TITLE: ***Investigate challenges faced by Chinese university students in the UK and evaluate solutions***

Introduction

China is the largest source of international students, with around 703,500 Chinese students pursuing overseas studies in 2019 (Ministry of Education of the People's Republic of China, 2020). Chinese students who go abroad may benefit academically, economically, and psychologically from the experience. At the same time, at least in the short term, they can face particular hardships far away from their own culture and family. Culture shock is perhaps the most serious problem they encounter, especially in countries whose cultures differ markedly from their own. This essay will examine the issues Chinese students encounter while at university in the UK in respect of homesickness and the language barrier, and solutions will be evaluated.

Paragraph 1

Read the following paragraph that explains a problem carefully. Match the functions with the sentences. The sentences are in the correct order:

1. One of the primary challenges faced by Chinese students at UK universities is homesickness, which can significantly affect overall well-being. **2.** It is typically characterised by an intense longing for home and persistent feelings of discomfort and disorientation. **3.** These feelings often stem from the physical separation from familiar support networks in China, such as close-knit family relationships, long-standing friendships, and community ties. **4.** In the absence of this emotional support – which provides reassurance, a sense of being cared for, and encouragement during periods of stress – students may find it difficult to cope with the psychosocial demands of living abroad. **5.** Emotional distress may be further intensified by cultural differences between China and the UK, which can contribute to a sense of isolation and disconnection from both peers and their accustomed social norms (Spencer-Oatey & Dauber, 2019). **6.** In some cases, such distress may compel students to return to their home country before completing their studies.

a) ……. Topic Sentence
b) ……. Serious Consequence
c) ……. Cause/Reason
d) ……. Definition/Clarification
e) ……. Impact/Consequence
f) ……. Additional Factor

Paragraph 2 (missing)

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Paragraph 3

Read the following solution/evaluation paragraph carefully. Write your own topic sentence and match the functions with the sentences. The functions are in the correct order:

1. Nonetheless, a potential drawback of themed residences is the risk of forming cultural enclaves, which may unintentionally reinforce segregation from the wider campus community.

2. Cultural exchange initiatives…

3. The personal and empathetic relationships fostered in these spaces appear to mitigate the emotional strain often associated with geographical and cultural displacement.

4. Recent research supports the claim that such environments can significantly reduce homesickness by promoting both intercultural understanding and a sense of belonging (Jones & Kim, 2023; García & Rodríguez, 2019; Smith, 2024).

5. This risk, however, can be addressed through regular assessment and feedback mechanisms designed to ensure that the original aims of inclusivity and intercultural engagement are being met (Bista & Foster, 2016).

6. One such initiative is the development of themed residence halls, such as the 'Chinese House', which provide a structured environment for cross-cultural interaction and the cultivation of meaningful social bonds between Chinese students and their international or domestic peers.

a) …. Topic sentence introducing the main idea of the paragraph

b) …. Specific example of a cultural exchange initiative

c) …. Research-based support

d) …. Explanation of how initiative helps reduce homesickness

e) …. Acknowledgement of a possible limitation

f) …. Refinement of solution

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Paragraph 4

The language barrier is another significant issue for Chinese university students, with attendant consequences. Although many have studied English prior to their arrival, they may struggle with the academic and colloquial use of the language in the UK. Such problems may be compounded by the imposition of Western educational protocols and practices, particularly in areas that emphasize individuality, critical thinking, and active classroom participation (Yang, 2010, cited in; Zhao & McDougall, 2008). These educational practices often contrast with the more collective and teacher-centered learning approaches prevalent in Chinese educational systems and can lead to miscommunications in the classroom. As students struggle to adapt, feelings of anxiety and disconnection may intensify, adversely impacting both social interactions and academic performance.

Paragraph 5

Challenges related to language competency can be addressed by initiatives to improve English language learning skills. Tailored language support programs that focus on both academic and conversational English can help Chinese students to gain confidence in the classroom and strengthen their communication skills. Additionally, structured language workshops that integrate cultural contexts could provide a more immersive and engaging learning experience. Critics rightly argue that this type of program is resource-intensive, requiring qualified instructors and materials, and may pose challenges for universities with large international student populations (Atobatele, Kpodo & Eke, 2024). On the other hand, the long-term benefits will not only improve language proficiency in the long term but also enhance integration, leading to higher retention rates and ultimately benefiting the university's appeal to future international students.

Paragraph 6

A process of ‘culture synergy’ (CS) has been proposed by Cortazzi and Jin (2013) to bring culture into language learning. It refers to the idea of leveraging the cultural backgrounds of students and teachers to create a more enriching learning environment. In practice, this means both teachers and students are encouraged to familiarize themselves with each other’s cultures, so teaching styles may become more attuned to students’ needs, while students learn to recalibrate their learning attitudes and expectations. The underlying assumption of this concept is that language acquisition cannot be dissociated from cultural comprehension, and hence that the quality of language learning partly hinges on a teacher’s knowledge of the students’ culture. This premise appears to be supported by Yao & Tian’s (2023) research which showed that when teachers integrated cultural elements into their teaching, it led to more effective communication and better learning experiences for students.

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Paragraph 7

While several strategies have been introduced to support Chinese students in overcoming both emotional and academic challenges, their effectiveness may vary significantly. Peer mentoring and culturally themed accommodation can help ease homesickness, yet participation may be limited by cultural reluctance to seek help, and without careful design, such initiatives risk reinforcing social separation rather than fostering integration. Likewise, language support programs may lack sufficient resources or are viewed as remedial, reducing their appeal. In contrast, *culture synergy* - which embeds cultural understanding directly into everyday teaching practices not only supports students' language development but also fosters a stronger sense of belonging, effectively addressing both academic and emotional adjustment. This dual-focus approach enables institutions to 'kill two birds with one stone', promoting language proficiency and psychological well-being through inclusive, reciprocal engagement between students and educators. Although it demands institutional commitment and pedagogical flexibility, *culture synergy* can offer the most comprehensive and sustainable strategy for supporting Chinese students in higher education.

Conclusion **(see page 11)**

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ESSAY STRUCTURES

Below are three sample structures for a problem–solution + evaluation essay. Read each structure carefully, then complete the activity that follows.

Structure 1: Classic Problem–Solution–Evaluation

I. Introduction: Introduce topic and outline main points.
II. Problem 1 – Description and Impact.
III. Solution 1 – Explanation and Limitations.
IV. Problem 2 – Description and Impact.
V. Solution 2 – Explanation and Evaluation.
VI. Evaluation Paragraph – Compare all solutions and justify the best.
VII. Conclusion – Summarise and reflect on broader implications.

Structure 2: Problem–Multiple Solutions–Critical Evaluation

I. Introduction – Introduce topic, outline the main points.
II. Problem Description – Define the issue and explain causes, effects, and significance.
III. Solution 1 – Describe a possible solution and evaluate its effectiveness.
IV. Solution 2 – Introduce an alternative approach and critically analyse its effectiveness.
V. Solution 3 - Introduce an alternative approach and critically analyse its effectiveness.
VI. Critical Evaluation – Compare solutions and justify which is most effective based on evidence.
VII. Conclusion – Summarise problem and solutions, reaffirm the best option, and offer final reflection.

Identify the structure

Task:

1. Review the three structures above.
2. Decide which one best matches the structure used in the essay on the previous pages.
3. Justify your choice in the space below by referring to how the content fits the structure.

Structure chosen:

Justification:

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SAMPLE CONCLUSION FOR THE ABOVE ESSAY

1. Decide how frequently the following items are included in a conclusion for a short essay (700-900 words):

a) A summary of the main points (*always / often / sometimes / never)*

b) New information that may be of interest (*always / often / sometimes / never)*

c) A recommendation / solution / prediction (*always / often / sometimes / never)*

d) A citation (*always / often / sometimes / never)*

e) Your opinion (*always / often / sometimes / never)*

f) A definition (*always / often / sometimes / never)*

2. Which 4 words/expressions below commonly begin a conclusion?

overall	to sum up	to conclude	in a word
in summary	last but not least	lastly	in conclusion

SAMPLE CONCLUSION FOR ESSAY

1. Write the correct form of each word in parentheses:

In conclusion, Chinese students studying at universities in the UK frequently face **a) (SUBSTANCE)** ……. challenges, particularly in relation to homesickness and language difficulties, both of which can undermine emotional **b) (RESILIENT)** ……. and academic performance. Although support **c)** (**INITIATE**) ……. such as peer mentoring, culturally themed accommodation, and language development programmes offer meaningful assistance, their effectiveness is often **d) (CONSTRAINT)** ……. by cultural barriers, limited institutional resources, or fragmented implementation. Among the various strategies available, the concept of *culture synergy* emerges as the most comprehensive and impactful. **e) (INTEGRATION)** ……. cultural awareness into core teaching practices allows institutions to address the linguistic and emotional aspects of international student adjustment in a **f) (COHESION)** ……. manner. Crucially, this model promotes

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a deeper sense of connection and belonging, which are foundational to student success and **g) (RETAIN)** …….. For UK universities striving to cultivate globally inclusive learning environments, culturally responsive models such as *culture synergy* represent not only a practical solution but also a strategic and **h) ENDURE** ……. commitment to the success of their international student populations.

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INTRODUCTIONS REVIEW

1. Label each sentence to indicate the type of information provided:

ESSAY TITLE: *Assess the impact of privatization on the performance of the UK economy*

a) …… In recent years the privatization of state-owned businesses, especially monopoly utilities such as electricity and telecoms, has become widespread in both developed and developing nations.

b) ……. Privatization refers to the process of certain industries from state control to the private sector, which began in Britain in 1981 with British Telecom.

c) ……. As privatization is increasingly seen as a solution for economic problems in many other countries, it is worth examining its impact in Britain, which was a pioneer in this process.

d) ……. Only privatizations completed between 1985-2000 will be considered, as it is too soon to assess the repercussions of later developments.

e) …… This essay will evaluate the effects of privatization on the UK's economic performance at the level of individual industries themselves and the UK as a whole.

2. Analyze the thesis statement to answer the following questions:

a) Note down the key question verb that verb that introduces the writer's thesis statement: ……..…...

b) Which words have paraphrased *assess*, *impact* and *economy*?

……..……..……..…….

GENERALITY VERSUS SPECIFICITY IN AN OPENING SENTENCE

The first sentence should be neither too general nor too specific:

- *Recently, governments have expanded censorship.* ✗ (Too short and general)
- *Recently, governments worldwide have expanded censorship to cover a growing diversity of topics.*✓

1. Write introductory sentences and thesis statements for three of the following essay titles below, and compare your answers with your partner:

a) *Describe the benefits of AI to society*

Introductory sentence: .....

.....

Thesis statement: .....

.....

b) *Outline the most serious types of urban pollution*

Introductory sentence: .....

.....

Thesis statement: .....

.....

c) *Explore the causes of insomnia among students*

Introductory sentence: .....

.....

Thesis statement: .....

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.....

d) *Analyze the benefits of learning a second language*

Introductory sentence: .....

.....

Thesis statement: .....

.....

e) *Comment on the differences between academic English and general/social English*

Introductory sentence: .....

.....

Thesis statement: .....

.....

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SAMPLE SHORT ESSAY (740 words)

ESSAY TITLE: *Describe the UK university education system.*

SCANNING

Decide whether the following statements are True (T) or False (F) according to the information given in the essay:

a)	Cambridge university has produced more Nobel laureates that any other university	**T/F**
b)	Students attend lectures in order to debate issues	**T/F**
c)	UK University students rely heavily on tutors for advice about study materials	**T/F**
d)	Critical thinking includes assessing someone's opinions	**T/F**
e)	University lecturers are less informal than high school teachers	**T/F**
f)	A "2-1" degree is awarded to students who obtain a grade between 50% and 60%	**T/F**
g)	Few students are awarded a Distinction	**T/F**

Describe the UK University Education System

University education in the UK can be traced back to the founding of Oxford in 1167 and Cambridge in 1209. Since then, UK universities have established a reputation for excellence, due partly to their **significant** research output. Cambridge, for example, has produced 83 Nobel prize-winners - more than any other university internationally. In order to create a learning environment that is **conducive** to research while preparing students for their future careers, the universities have adopted an approach to education generally aimed at **fostering** analytical ability and the capacity for original thought. The purpose of this essay is to examine five fundamental aspects of this system: class size, critical thinking and independent learning, student-tutor interactions, and the university grading system.

University classes can be classified into three main types, each serving specific functions. Lectures take the form of a presentation from a lecturer and can hold 200-300 students who listen and take notes. They are therefore a **relatively** efficient means of supplying information to large numbers. Seminars are usually classes of around 10-15 students, and often require a presentation, followed by an informal discussion in which the students and tutor offer opinions and critical analysis. Tutorials are similar to seminars, but smaller, and are intended to intellectually

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challenge each student to think creatively, and to **rigorously** defend his/her own ideas while analyzing and criticizing the arguments of others.

Critical thinking and independent learning are essential components of the UK university system, to promote analysis and original ideas. Critical thinking refers to many skills, especially the ability to evaluate arguments and give valid and logical reasons for an opinion. These skills are **implemented** in all areas of academic study, including academic writing, discussion, presentations and research. Students are also encouraged to learn independently, which means they make their own decisions about which readings are requisite for their area of study; it also means that they reflect on their needs, make self-study plans, and assess their own performance. In this manner, students can become more aware of their strengths and weaknesses and less dependent on their tutors, while developing their research interests.

Relationships between tutors and students at university are relatively casual, and there is greater personal interaction than at high school. In contrast to teachers in high school, most university tutors will be informal with students, partly because the university students are regarded as young adults, and also because **informality** is seen as fostering trust, communication and the sharing of ideas. There are also opportunities for more direct contact with tutors in seminars and tutorials, as well as in individual meetings with personal tutors where the student is free to discuss any problems that might be affecting his/her studies. Moreover, tutors are respectful of students and vice versa, since it is expected that not only will the student acquire knowledge from the tutor, but that the tutor can also learn from the student as a mature adult.

In order to measure the success or failure of students for coursework and examinations, universities make use of five different ranges of percentages. The 'fail' level is below 40%; the second level is a "third," which is 40% to 49%; the next level is a "2:2," representing 50% to 59%; and a "2:1" falls between 60% and 69%. A "first," or "distinction" (70% or above), signifies excellence, and is the highest award that a student can receive for a piece of work or for an exam result. For most **disciplines**, only a small minority of students, approximately 15%, obtain a first, and the majority of students are awarded marks in the 50's. This grading system can be difficult to deal with for international students who may be **accustomed** to achieving 80% or 90% on average. UK Universities can therefore offer a highly competitive and challenging environment.

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VOCABULARY

1. Find the following words in the essay, study the context in which they are found, and then **choose the definition given which you think best expresses the meaning:**

1. significant (adj)
2. conducive (to) (adj)
3. foster (verb)
4. relatively (adv)
5. challenge (verb)
6. rigorously (adv)
7. implement (verb)
8. informality (noun)
9. discipline (noun)
10. accustomed (to) (adj)

a) _____ to a fairly large degree, especially in comparison with something else

b) _____ to start to use (a new plan, system, strategy, etc.)

c) _____ (being) in the habit of

d) _____ contributive, providing the right conditions for something good to happen or exist

e) _____ large or important enough to have an effect or to be noticed

f) _____ to test somebody's ability and skills, especially in an interesting way

g) _____ a relaxed, friendly, or unofficial style or nature

h) _____ done by paying lot of attention to detail

i) _____ an area of knowledge

j) _____ to encourage something to develop

2. Match each of the following words with its synonym in the vocabulary items above:

TERM	SYNONYM	TERM	SYNONYM
favourable (to) (adj)		somewhat (adv)	
substantial (adj)		used (to) (adj)	
casualness (noun)		apply (verb)	
encourage (verb)		stimulate (verb)	
carefully (adv)		subject (noun)	

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3. Complete the following sentences using an appropriate form of one of the terms in Exercise 1:

a) The location was carefully chosen to create an atmosphere …… to open discussion.

b) A successful future for humanity will require the ……. of a culture of sustainability.

c) Even as far back as the Middle Ages, bread has been of great ……. to French people.

d) Resources were made available to facilitate the ……. of these strategies.

e) This technique is ……. easy to automate.

f) The lecturer had an ……. manner that put the students at ease.

g) The recent explosion in the development of AI has been driven by a specific …… of AI called machine learning.

h) Managing the Euro will continue to be a……. task for the EU.

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WRITE YOUR OWN CONCLUSION

1. Write the conclusion for the essay: *Describe the UK university education system*. **Remember to include appropriate sections:**

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PEER EVALUATION

Evaluate your partner's conclusion: **Student name: ……**

CONCLUSION	✖ / ✓
The conclusion begins with the words: *In conclusion, to conclude, in summary,* or *to sum up*	
A brief summary of main points from the main body of the essay is provided	
No new information is given in the summary	
The student's opinion is given	
A recommendation, prediction or suggestion is included at the end of the conclusion	
No irrelevant details are given	

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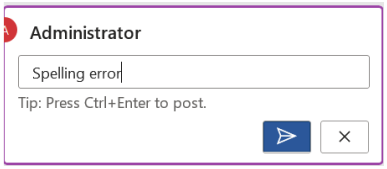
PEER EVALUATION OF INTRODUCTION

GRAMMAR

a) Try to find some grammatical errors in your partner's introduction. You should use track changes where possible and also indicate errors using comments. For example:

It is esential to gain a high-level degree…



b) Note how many errors occur in the table:

Type of error	Number of errors	Type of error	Number of errors
ww = wrong word		prep = wrong preposition	
number = word should be singular or plural?		art = article should be changed or deleted	
tense = wrong tense		vf = wrong form of verb	
p = wrong punctuation		wf = wrong form of word	
informal = informal word used		^ = word missing	
/ = unnecessary word		sp = wrong spelling	
wo = wrong word order		? meaning unclear	
cs = comma splice (run-on sentence)			

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RECORDING NEW VOCABULARY

You may use this page to record important new vocabulary:

WORD	PRONUNCIATION	WORD FORM	
Example sentence(s)			
Example sentence(s)			
Example sentence(s)			
Example sentence(s)			
Example sentence(s)			
Example sentence(s)			
Example sentence(s)			

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WORD	PRONUNCIATION	WORD FORM	
Example sentence(s)			
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